Week 4: Cover Letters, Personal Statements, and Application Packages

- **CV**: compressed evidence into bullets, for a scanning reader
- **Today**: expand evidence into an argument, for a specific reader (who is deciding whether **you chose them** on purpose)

Two “openers”

GENERIC

“I am writing to apply for the position advertised on your website. I am a highly motivated student with a strong passion for bioengineering.”

SPECIFIC

“Your company's work on real-time brain machine interface control is the topic I most want to work on: in my master thesis I simulated a feedback-controlled neuronal network and found that stimulation timing, not amplitude, decided whether elicited bursts synchronized.”

Two genres

Industry cover letter

One page, 3-4 short paragraphs.

A hook tied to their product, problem, or vision and your own best bullets mapped to the posting's own words, a concrete next step.

"I will help solve your problem."

Research motivation statements

PhD, postdoc, (or master thesis position). Often longer than 1 page. Check each call.

The question that drives you, your background, why this lab's methods fit, what you would do there. Name people and published papers.

"I can think, and your question draws me."

A cover letter is never "an island"

The documents

CV, letter, exam score transcripts, a portfolio or GitHub link, recommendation letters.

The consistency

Same facts, same names, same pitch as your LinkedIn and Scholar pages

The referees

Ask weeks ahead. Send your CV, the posting, and your draft. Ask "could you write a strong letter?"

BTW: Two recommendations exist: good and excellent. You do NOT want a good one.

Write the core paragraph of your letter

A

PhD position, neuroengineering lab;

C

Field applications engineer, neuro-instrumentation company

E

Junior R&D, Mirandola biovalley dialysis company

B

Master thesis, translational neurotechnology lab

D

Regulatory affairs intern, medical device company

5:00

Sentence 1. Name something specific about the target.

Sentences 2–4. Expand last week's bullet into evidence tied to a stated requirement.

Last sentence. Why now: what this position lets you do next.

Swap-the-name

Industry cover letter

Mentally replace the target's name with another organization in the same field. Does the paragraph still work unchanged?

If yes, it is generic. Underline the most specific sentence and the most generic one.

Using an LLM to draft?

Fine, but the specifics **must** come from you.

A LLM will happily write a paragraph that survives the name swap.

This test catches it.

Listen for the “why now”

- As today’s guest tells their story, notice why they chose that lab or company, and why at that moment.
- Next week: online presence. Your letter’s claims should be findable where a reader will look.

Drug Delivery System for Neurological Disorders

Audrey Franceschi Biagioni, PhD

Researcher & Entrepeneur, Sindrel MedTech